

The Meridian Course

Instructor's Learning Summary — Competencies & Learning Objectives

This document gives instructors, program directors, and CME/CE reviewers a complete map of the program's educational design: the competency framework, module-level learning objectives, behavioral assessment anchors, the pedagogy behind the six-step rhythm, and facilitation guidance for cohort use. The Meridian Course is a simulation-based program in which healthcare leaders "round" on strategic situations across a persistent fictional health system, pairing one game-theoretic lens per module with the TeamSTEPPS and communication tools that act on it.

Pedagogical design

The program is built on four evidence-based commitments:

1 · Deliberate practice over exposition

Each module's concepts are taught briefly (vignette + Socratic coaching), then immediately exercised in scored, branching simulations where AI counterparts hold their own incentives, histories, and hidden information. Counterparts resist weak moves and reward skilled ones; success requires performing the target behaviors, not describing them.

2 · Perspective-taking as a repeated mechanic

After every one-on-one simulation, the **Switch Chairs** activity replays the identical scenario with roles inverted: the learner plays their former counterpart. Empathy is not a module in this program; it is rehearsed eight times, each time revealing the counterpart's constraints, fears, and rational logic from the inside.

3 · Advocacy-inquiry debriefing (Debriefing with Good Judgment)

Every module closes with a structured debrief in the Rudolph et al. tradition: the debriefer pairs an observation and honest interpretation with a genuine question ("I noticed X; it made me think Y; what was going on for you?"). Debriefs always end in a written, time-bound **commitment to practice** applied to the learner's real organization — and Modules 4, 7, and 8 explicitly revisit earlier commitments, creating longitudinal evidence of transfer.

4 · A persistent world that makes the repeated game felt

Seventeen recurring personas carry stable incentives, communication styles, and memory across modules. Relational choices compound: trust built (or spent) with the charge nurse in Module 3 changes what is possible in Module 7's coalition. This architecture teaches the program's central lesson structurally — in healthcare, you never play a one-shot game.

Assessment architecture

LAYER	INSTRUMENT	NOTES FOR INSTRUCTORS
Knowledge	5 branching-case MCQs per module (40 total), distractors built from documented misconceptions	Every option carries teaching feedback; items are tagged to a competency map (game concept × communication tool × ethical frame) for mastery tracking.
Performance	Behaviorally anchored rubrics scoring all 24 simulations (66 dimensions)	Anchors are observable behaviors (e.g., closed-loop completion, acknowledgment-before-advocacy). Meters are calibrated so perfect play fills them; branch outcomes (strong / provisional / mixed) narrate consequences.
Transfer	Written commitments to practice, revisited in later modules; Module 8's summative "personal playbook"	The playbook (default tendency + counter-practice + one influenceable mechanism + one standing ritual) is the program's terminal artifact — suitable for portfolio review or coaching follow-up.

Facilitation note. In cohort settings, the debrief prompts double as small-group discussion guides, and the simulation outcome bands make excellent case-comparison material ("who reached the strong branch, and what did you do differently?"). The Switch Chairs transfer questions are the highest-yield discussion starters in the program.

Competency framework

Six competencies organize the program. Each module develops several; the capstone requires all six at once. (Mapping: ● = primary development site, ○ = reinforced.)

COMPETENCY	DEFINITION
C1 Strategic Diagnosis	Read situations as games — identify players, strategies, payoffs, and information; distinguish cooperation, coordination, information, and mechanism failures, because their fixes differ completely.
C2 Structured Team Communication	Deploy TeamSTEPPS tools (SBAR, check-back, CUS, two-challenge rule, briefs/huddles/debriefs) as strategic instruments that create common knowledge and psychological safety — not as ritual.
C3 Negotiation & Influence	Excavate interests beneath positions, compute and improve BATNAs, defend against anchors, create value before claiming it, and build coalitions through pivotal-player analysis and honest tailoring.
C4 Relational Capital & Repair	Play repeated games well: choose strategies that sustain cooperation, forgive noise without licensing patterns, deliver costly apologies, and visibly reward the first mover who speaks up.
C5 Ethical Reasoning & Legitimacy	Apply utilitarian, deontological, and justice frameworks as complementary error-detectors; design procedurally just processes; deliver decisions people will hate with honesty, empathy, and transparency.
C6 Systems & Mechanism Design	Redesign rules so ordinary self-interest produces desired outcomes: incentive compatibility, Goodhart's law, pre-mortems, counter-metrics, and humane transition design.

Competency × module map

MODULE	C1	C2	C3	C4	C5	C6
1 · Morning Report	●	●	○	○	○	○
2 · The Handoff	●	●	○		○	○
3 · Repeat Customers	○	●		●	○	○
4 · The Contract Table	○	○	●	○	○	
5 · The Rapid Response	●	●		○	○	○
6 · The Allocation Meeting	○	○		○	●	●
7 · The Coalition	○	○	●	●	●	○
8 · The System Redesign	●	●	●	●	●	●

Cross-cutting thread — Perspective-Taking & Empathy: rehearsed in every module through Switch Chairs and scored via empathy markers (naming and legitimizing emotion, honoring the counterpart's rational constraints). Instructors should treat it as a seventh, ambient competency assessed everywhere and lectured nowhere.

Module learning objectives & assessment anchors

Objectives are written to be observable in the module's own simulations; "the learner will be able to..." is implied throughout.

ROUND 1 · EXECUTIVE SUITE · C1 C2

Morning Report — The Games We Are Already Playing

Prisoner's Dilemma · tragedy of the commons · psychological safety

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Identify the players, strategies, payoffs, and information structure in a workplace conflict, and name when a Prisoner's Dilemma or commons structure is operating.
- ◆ Predict the equilibrium behavior a given incentive structure will produce, and explain why exhortation fails to change it.
- ◆ Design an intervention that changes payoffs (protection, verification, reversion) rather than appealing to goodwill.
- ◆ Demonstrate acknowledgment-before-advocacy when proposing cooperation to a previously exploited counterpart.
- ◆ Surface a hidden group dynamic in a committee without attributing blame to any individual.

SIMULATIONS & SCORING ANCHORS

One-on-one: capacity-sharing proposal to a burned peer director — *acknowledgment before advocacy; payoff-changing structure; trust trajectory.*

Meeting: capacity committee — *system framing; blame avoidance; psychological-safety moves that surface held-back information.*

Debrief focus: where a Prisoner's Dilemma operates in the learner's organization, and one changeable payoff.

ROUND 2 · ED → INPATIENT MEDICINE · C1 C2

The Handoff — Information Asymmetry and Signaling

Signaling & screening · cheap talk vs. costly signals · SBAR as protocol

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Distinguish cheap talk from costly signals, and weight messages by what they cost the sender.
- ◆ Design screening questions that force different underlying realities to produce audibly different answers.
- ◆ Conduct a structured information handoff using targeted screens and check-backs that convert disclosures into explicit plans.
- ◆ Apply pressure for information without hostility, preserving the sending relationship for future exchanges.
- ◆ Reframe SBAR and structured handoffs as mechanisms that solve information asymmetry — and redesign a message format so critical content cannot be compressed out.

SIMULATIONS & SCORING ANCHORS

One-on-one: the 55-second handoff from a rushed ED attending — *screen design; closed loops; pressure without hostility.*

Meeting: M&M-style handoff review — *system framing over trial; blame defused; a forced-field signaling protocol produced and co-owned.*

Debrief focus: the learner's own asymmetries — including where they are the compressing sender.

ROUND 3 · COMMUNITY HOSPITAL · C2 C4

Repeat Customers — Reputation, Trust, and the Shadow of the Future

Repeated games · Axelrod's tournaments · repair after defection

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Classify relationships as one-shot or repeated games and select strategies (generous tit-for-tat) accordingly.
- ◆ Apply the noise test — run one clarifying question before retaliating against an apparent defection.
- ◆ Deliver a costly apology: name the specific act and audience, own the harm without an exculpatory clause, and attach a checkable forward commitment.

SIMULATIONS & SCORING ANCHORS

One-on-one: repairing the dismissed charge nurse — *specific acknowledgment; costly apology; enforceable commitment.*

Meeting: the safety huddle that learned silence — *making challenge cheap; rewarding the first mover; installing mechanisms that outlive the meeting.*

Debrief focus: a real repair, specified — or a first mover's loop the learner will close visibly.

- ◆ Match public repair to public defection, restoring the price of speaking up for witnesses as well as the injured party.
- ◆ Rebuild a silent team's reporting culture by visibly rewarding the first mover who tests the new price of candor.

ROUND 4 · PAYER RELATIONS · C3

The Contract Table — Negotiation and Bargaining*BATNA · interests vs. positions · anchoring · the negotiator's dilemma*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Compute and price a BATNA before negotiating, and identify actions that improve it away from the table.
- ◆ Excavate interests beneath stated positions with questions that invite information rather than defense.
- ◆ Neutralize an anchor by re-anchoring on objective criteria, then pivot to integrative ground.
- ◆ Construct value-creating trades across asymmetric interests — then claim a defensible share with a rationale the counterpart can ratify internally.
- ◆ Forge a unified internal mandate: a true reservation point, ordered red lines, bounded authority, and an escalation protocol.

SIMULATIONS & SCORING ANCHORS

One-on-one: the payer renewal with hidden flexibility — *interest discovery; value creation; relationship preservation.*

Meeting: the pre-negotiation mandate huddle — *forging the mandate; surfacing hidden constraints; the negotiator's charter.*

Debrief focus: mapping a real upcoming negotiation — both parties' interests and BATNAs, one integrative option.

ROUND 5 · RAPID RESPONSE · C1 C2

The Rapid Response — Coordination Games and Communication Under Pressure*Coordination vs. cooperation failures · focal points · common knowledge*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Differentiate coordination failures from cooperation failures, and select convergence fixes versus payoff fixes accordingly.
- ◆ Explain how protocols and standard concentrations manufacture focal points, and how closed-loop communication creates common knowledge.
- ◆ Escalate a clinical concern through graded assertiveness — concern with data → CUS → two-challenge rule — without skipping rungs or folding.
- ◆ Lead an emergency response with named role assignments, demanded confirmations, and licensed call-outs; close every loop audibly.
- ◆ Conduct a two-minute team debrief that converts one event's coordination into the team's standing practice.

SIMULATIONS & SCORING ANCHORS

One-on-one: 03:10 graded assertiveness with an anchored senior physician — *assertion ladder; data-anchored advocacy; closed loops.*

Meeting: leading the rapid response — *closed-loop completion rate; surfacing held information; the team debrief.*

Debrief focus: where the learner's real team runs on assumed rather than common knowledge.

ROUND 6 · ETHICS COMMITTEE · C5 C6

The Allocation Meeting — Fairness, Ethics, and the Ultimatum at the Bedside*Ultimatum game · procedural vs. distributive justice · crisis standards*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Explain why fairness perceptions function as real payoffs, and predict how excluded stakeholders reject illegitimate processes.
- ◆ Distinguish procedural from distributive justice, and defend pre-committed transparent criteria over ad hoc bedside discretion.
- ◆ Apply utilitarian, deontological, and justice frameworks as complementary error-detectors, articulating what each protects that the others miss.

SIMULATIONS & SCORING ANCHORS

One-on-one: the family room — *honesty without armor; empathy markers; process transparency.*

Meeting: the ethics committee protocol review — *framework stewardship; voice for the missing; a defensible process produced.*

Debrief focus: the learner's default framework under pressure — and what the others would protect.

- ◆ Deliver a devastating decision without armor: the plain answer first, emotion named and legitimized, process transparent, promises scoped to actual authority.
- ◆ Facilitate sincere framework conflict toward a defensible, revisable process — with the missing voice given real authority, not speaking time.

ROUND 7 · INNOVATION OFFICE · C3 C4 C5

The Coalition — Politics, Alliances, and Getting Innovation Adopted*Pivotal players · sequencing · the ethics of influence*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Map stakeholders by pivotality (whose movement changes the outcome) rather than seniority, using the Shapley intuition.
- ◆ Sequence recruitment so pivotal skeptics get design access while the proposal can still move — objections requested before support.
- ◆ Surface operative objections beneath stated ones, and convert them into specifications the skeptic co-authors.
- ◆ Offer skeptics real instruments — kill clauses, overrides, audit triggers — and explain why instrumented opposition protects adoption.
- ◆ Tailor one true proposal to different stakeholders' interest-languages while passing the exposure test: all versions cohere if compared.

SIMULATIONS & SCORING ANCHORS

One-on-one: recruiting the pivotal skeptical chief — *surfacing true interests; design access granted; transparent influence.*

Meeting: the governance vote — *tailoring without forking; moving the genuine undecided; converting oppositions into governance roles.*

Debrief focus: a real initiative mapped as a coalition problem; the honest pitch for each party.

ROUND 8 · STRATEGY RETREAT · CAPSTONE · ALL COMPETENCIES

The System Redesign — Mechanism Design and Leading at Scale*Incentive compatibility · Goodhart's law · the pre-mortem discipline*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Diagnose organizational dysfunctions as equilibria of badly designed mechanisms — asking what the rules pay for before who failed.
- ◆ Redesign measures and incentives to the standard: gaming the metric and doing the right thing become the same behavior.
- ◆ Run the pre-mortem ("how would I hit this number without doing the work?") and attach counter-metrics to every target.
- ◆ Translate a mechanism redesign into financial language — downside, discovery cost, exit — while defending its load-bearing terms against gutting simplifications.
- ◆ Design humane transitions for those the old rules rewarded, and lead a multi-stakeholder redesign end-to-end using all prior modules' skills.
- ◆ Produce a personal leadership playbook: default tendency, counter-practice, one influenceable mechanism, one standing ritual.

SIMULATIONS & SCORING ANCHORS

One-on-one: penciling the redesign with the CFO — *financial translation; mechanism integrity; owning the history.*

Meeting (capstone): the strategy retreat — *mechanism diagnosis without villains; running the room; trade-offs priced; a mechanism shipped with owners, counter-metrics, and a sunset.*

Debrief focus: the summative playbook across all eight rounds.

Foundational references

- Agency for Healthcare Research and Quality. *TeamSTEPPS 3.0 Curriculum*.
- Rudolph JW, Simon R, Rivard P, Dufresne RL, Raemer DB. Debriefing with good judgment. *Anesthesiol Clin*. 2007;25(2):361–376.
- Axelrod R. *The Evolution of Cooperation*. Basic Books; 1984.
- Schelling T. *The Strategy of Conflict*. Harvard University Press; 1960.
- Fisher R, Ury W, Patton B. *Getting to Yes*. Penguin; 2011.
- Dixit A, Nalebuff B. *The Art of Strategy*. W. W. Norton; 2008.

- Güth W, Schmittberger R, Schwarze B. An experimental analysis of ultimatum bargaining. *J Econ Behav Organ.* 1982;3(4):367–388.
- Emanuel EJ, et al. Fair allocation of scarce medical resources in the time of Covid-19. *N Engl J Med.* 2020;382:2049–2055.
- Roth A. *Who Gets What — and Why.* Houghton Mifflin Harcourt; 2015.
- Kotter JP. *Leading Change.* Harvard Business Review Press; 2012.